

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Hebrews

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Have you ever known someone who stopped following Christ and left the church?

Maybe you have also found it hard to stay faithful to Christ. You may have felt disappointed, confused, or afraid. You may have suffered because of your faith.

The book of Hebrews points us to Christ. It helps struggling Christians see Jesus clearly and remain faithful to him.

Setting

As Christianity spread throughout the Mediterranean region, the first followers of Jesus Christ encountered serious challenges. Greek and Roman society often misunderstood and mistrusted Jews and Christians. Some people called them atheists because they did not worship the Greek or Roman gods.

Christians also faced opposition from some Jewish leaders and communities. Many Jews did not accept Jesus as the Messiah, the promised king and Savior. People who put their faith in Christ often suffered in serious ways. This was true for both Jewish and Gentile believers. They could lose work, family ties, friendships, and their place in society. Persecution, or suffering because of one's faith, was common for Christians.

Hebrews was probably written to believers who met in house churches in Rome in the early 60s AD. The Christian community in Rome may have begun in the AD 30s. Some people from Rome were present at Pentecost, the day when the Holy Spirit came on the followers of Jesus (Acts 2:10).

The believers in Rome had shown courage and endurance, or patient faithfulness, during hard times (Hebrews 10:32-34). But by the time Hebrews was written, some believers were no longer eager to listen to God and obey him (5:11-14). Some were in danger of drifting away from what they had heard about Christ (2:1). Some may have even left Christ and the church (6:4-8).

Summary

Hebrews is a strong and carefully written message for people who were struggling in their faith. It is written like a first-century sermon. The author teaches about who Christ is and what he has done. He also urges the readers to obey God and remain faithful.

The author speaks in detail about God's Son. He also gives warnings, challenges, examples, and reminders that God is faithful. Through all of this, he calls the readers to keep following Christ.

After the opening of the sermon (1:1-4), the author explains that Christ is greater than all others. He does this in two main sections.

The first section explains the Son's relationship to the angels (1:5-2:18). Angels are God's servants (1:6-7, 14). But the Son is greater than the angels. He has been exalted, or lifted up to the highest place of honor (1:13). He has a unique relationship with the Father (1:5). He is the Lord, the creator, and the one who keeps the universe in existence. He is God (1:8-12).

The author then urges the believers to pay close attention to the message of salvation they have received, God's rescue from sin and death through Christ (2:1-4).

Then the author continues his teaching. When Christ became human, he was made lower than the angels for a short time (2:5-9). Jesus shared our flesh and blood, which means he became fully human. He did this so he could die and set us free (2:10-18).

After this first teaching section, the author gives a warning and encouragement (3:1-4:13). He tells the believers they must keep obeying God in faith. He also reminds them that God still promises rest for his people.

The second main section explains the Son's role as our high priest (4:14-10:18). A high priest was the priest who represented the people before God. This section shows how Jesus is related to the Old Testament system of sacrifices.

The author first introduces this theme (4:14-16). Then he explains that God appointed the Son as the greater high priest (5:1-10). After this, the author warns the believers about their lack of spiritual growth (5:11-6:20).

The author then discusses Melchizedek. Melchizedek was a priest and king in the Old Testament. The author shows that Melchizedek was greater than the priests from Levi's family line (7:1-10). This helps explain why Jesus is the greater high priest "in the order of Melchizedek" (7:11-28).

In other words, Jesus did not become high priest in the usual way under the Old Testament law. That law said priests came from the tribe of Levi. Instead, God appointed Jesus with an oath, or solemn promise. Jesus serves as high priest because he has a life that cannot be destroyed.

The author then explains the better offering that this appointed high priest gives (8:3–10:18). Like the earthly priests, Jesus had to make an offering for sins. But his offering belongs to the new covenant, God’s new binding agreement with his people (8:7–13). This offering is greater than the sacrifices of the old covenant (9:1–10:18).

The final main section urges the believers to respond faithfully to the message about Christ (10:19–13:25). The book ends with a blessing and a formal closing (13:20–25).

Author

Unlike many other New Testament letters, Hebrews does not begin by naming its author or its first recipients. Many scholars today think this is because Hebrews was first written as a sermon.

Christians have discussed the author of Hebrews since the early centuries of the church. The book was shared together with Paul’s letters. Some early church leaders in the eastern Mediterranean world, such as Origen and Clement of Alexandria, said Paul wrote it. Other Christians, especially near Rome, did not think Paul wrote the book.

Almost all scholars today agree that Paul did not write Hebrews for these reasons:

1. Hebrews 2:3 says the author received the good news from people who first heard it from Christ. This does not sound like Paul’s own description of his calling (see Romans 1:1; 1 Corinthians 15:8; Galatians 1:11–16).
2. Hebrews uses a different style, set of images, and vocabulary from Paul’s letters. For example, Hebrews uses 169 words that do not appear anywhere else in the New Testament.

Over the centuries, Christians have suggested many other possible authors for Hebrews. These include Philip, Priscilla, Luke, Barnabas, Jude, and Clement of Rome.

One popular idea is that Apollos wrote Hebrews. Martin Luther was one of the first to suggest this. In Acts, Luke describes Apollos as an educated man from Alexandria. He spoke well and taught the Scriptures with power (Acts 18:24–26).

We cannot identify the author of Hebrews with certainty. But a careful study of the book shows us several things about the author:

1. Hebrews is written in excellent Greek. Its words and structure show that the author was highly educated.

2. The author was likely a powerful preacher. The author knew how to explain Scripture well and seems to have known large parts of the Old Testament by memory.
3. Most importantly, the author was a Christian leader who cared deeply for the readers. The author spoke to them with urgency and strong concern.

Hebrews is not only a theological work, or a careful study about God and faith. It is also a pastoral appeal, a message from a leader who wants to help struggling Christians remain faithful to Christ.

Recipients

The author writes, “Greet all your leaders and all the saints. Those from Italy send you greetings” (Hebrews 13:24). This suggests that the author was writing back to Italy, and probably to Rome. He was sending greetings from Italian Christians who were living or traveling in another place.

This letter’s first recipients seem to have known something about Jewish worship. The author often uses the Old Testament and teaches ideas that people in synagogues around the Mediterranean world would have known. This does not mean that all the first recipients were Jews. Many Gentiles were also connected to synagogues. Some were called God-fearers because they worshiped the God of Israel.

Occasion for Writing

Some Christians in this community were struggling to stay faithful while they suffered for their faith. Hebrews 10:32–39 suggests that these believers had faced persecution before and were facing it again. They had to remain faithful to Christ and the church while other people opposed them in public. Some were becoming weak in their faith. Others may have left the faith completely. So the author urges these people, who said they followed Christ, to keep openly trusting Christ and remain faithful to him.

If Hebrews was written to Rome, then this message of encouragement may have been written because of persecution under Emperor Nero. Nero strongly persecuted Christians in the mid-60s AD, and some Christians were killed for their faith.

Hebrews may also have been written after AD 70. But this seems less likely. When Hebrews was written, it appears that no one in the community had yet been killed for their faith (see 12:4). Still, the pressure of persecution was increasing.

Meaning and Message

God has spoken about his Son and through his Son (1:1-3). Those who do not listen and obey will face serious judgment (2:1-3). Jesus created the universe and keeps it in existence (1:2-3). In the end, he will bring the present creation to an end. Hebrews compares this to someone rolling up old clothing and putting it away (1:10-12).

Jesus is fully worthy of our faithfulness, worship, and patient trust. He is greater than the angels (1:5-14). He is greater than Moses (3:1-6). He is also greater than the Levitical priesthood, the priests from Levi's family line who served under the old covenant (5:1-10; 7:1-28).

Jesus has made a new, heavenly covenant, with God's people. He offered himself once for all when he died (8:3-10:18). In his incarnation, when he became human, Jesus remained faithful as God's Son (3:1-6; 5:7-8; 12:1-2). In his exaltation, when God raised him to the highest place of honor, Jesus rules as the Lord of all creation (1:2-4, 8-13). Because Jesus is greater than all others and has completed God's saving work, Christians have the strongest reason to stay faithful to him and trust God's future promise.

We can learn from people who stayed faithful as they moved toward God's eternal city (see 6:13-15; 10:32-39; 11:1-40). We can also learn from people who disobeyed God and fell away from him (see 3:7-19; 6:4-8). And we can trust God's promises about our inheritance, the future blessing he gives to his children (see 4:3-11; 6:13-20; 12:22-24).

Because of Jesus, we can live as faithful members of the Christian community. We can honor him in our relationships and in our worship (13:1-17). We can follow Christ more faithfully as we understand him more clearly. We need to know who Jesus is and what he has done for us.